Lok Janshakti Party (LJP) and the Congress. The Bihar Legislative Assembly had 243 seats, making 122 the magic number required to secure an absolute majority in the assembly and form a stable government. However, that number proved elusive. The elections yielded a hung assembly, with no party or alliance within striking distance of the magic number. The NDA secured ninety-two seats, while the RJD, the LJP and the Congress secured seventy-five, twenty-nine and ten seats respectively. Six other political parties secured at least one seat, and seventeen independent candidates were elected.

The governor of a state assumes heightened responsibility in circumstances where there is a hung assembly, as he has the authority to invite those that are most likely to cobble a majority to form the government. The role of Buta Singh, Bihar's governor, therefore became crucial following the election results. Singh was 'no novice to politics' and had aligned with different political forces over the years – including as home minister in Rajiv Gandhi's Congress government and communications minister in Atal Bihari Vajpayee's NDA government.[1] Singh held a series of meetings with political parties in the days after the election results were declared. However, he concluded that no party or alliance was in a position to mobilize a majority in the assembly. This was predominantly because the LJP, which could effectively play the role of kingmaker between the NDA on the one side and the RJD–Congress combination on the other, chose not to extend support to either.

Singh therefore wrote to the President of India recommending that President's rule be imposed in Bihar, with the assembly being kept in a state of 'suspended animation' (this meant that although the assembly would not be dissolved, it could not transact any business). The idea was that this course of action would leave more time and space for discussions and political realignments. The President accepted this recommendation, resulting in Bihar effectively being administered by the United Progressive Alliance (UPA) government in New Delhi.

The process of political realignments envisaged by the governor was then well and truly set into motion. First, the group of seventeen